

KONNECT

THE NORTH KASHMIR CONNECTION



77 Years of Sovereignty

As the tricolor unfurls against the winter sky, India stands at a magnificent crossroads of tradition and transformation. Celebrating our 77th Republic Day, we do more than honor a date; we celebrate the enduring spirit of a Constitution that turned a diverse sub-continent into a singular, vibrant democracy.

From the snow-capped peaks of the Himalayas to the sun-drenched shores of the south, the heartbeat of the Republic is found in its people. Today, we witness an India that is both an ancient civilization and a modern powerhouse—leading in digital innovation, space exploration, and sustainable growth, while remaining rooted in the timeless philosophy of Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam—the world is one family.

Being a Republic means the power to dream is no longer a privilege, but a right. As we pay homage to the visionaries who drafted our destiny, we also salute the silent guardians of our frontiers and the everyday heroes building our future. On this 77th milestone, let us renew our pledge to justice, liberty, and fraternity.



The Rise Of Gulshan Begum



Riyaz UL Hassans Digital Crusade
for Kashmiri



Uznain Ashraf and new era
of Kashmiri Hockey

A HISTORIC MARCH: KUPWARA'S OWN LEADS THE NATION



In a moment of unparalleled pride for the North Kashmir frontier, Senior Under-officer Tawheed Altaf has etched his name into the history books: hailing from the quiet village of Shehlal, Handwara, Tawheed became the first cadet from Jammu, Kashmir, and Ladakh to lead the All-India NCC Boys Marching Contingent at the 77th Republic Day Parade on Kartavya Path. Commanding a 148-member contingent before the President of India, his journey—from the classrooms of Government Boys Higher Secondary School, Handwara, to the heart of the national capital—stands as a powerful testament to grit and discipline. Under the guidance of the 7 J&K Battalion NCC Kupwara, a unit established only a few years ago, he emerged through a stringent selection process,

proving that talent from remote border districts can outshine the rest on the national stage. His mentors, including Lt. Abdul Rasheed Sheikh, recall a cadet defined by sheer dedication; for the youth of Kupwara and Handwara, Tawheed is no longer just a neighbor—he is a beacon of what is possible through the National Cadet Corps. As he marched past the saluting base, he didn't just lead a contingent: he carried the aspirations of an entire region, proving that the road from North Kashmir leads straight to the pinnacle of national honor.



ROOTED IN RESILIENCE: THE RISE OF GULSHAN BEGUM

In the quiet hamlet of Dudipora, Handwara, 35-year-old Gulshan Begum is redefining female empowerment through a journey rooted in resilience and self-belief. Once a nursing graduate waiting for a government post, Gulshan chose to write her own destiny in the soil of her home—transforming a modest polyhouse proposal into a flourishing agricultural enterprise that yielded nearly ₹2 lakh in profit within its first year. Her journey is a masterclass in integrated farming; not content with a single success, she leveraged scientific training from KVK Kupwara to diversify into mushroom cultivation, dairy, and livestock, growing a personal investment of ten sheep into a thriving flock of thirty-five. Today, she stands not as a job seeker, but as a purposeful employer of local youth, championing agriculture as a dignified shield against the region's social challenges. Supported by the unwavering encouragement of her family and the scientific community at SKUAST-Kashmir, Gulshan's story serves as a powerful reminder to the youth of North Kashmir that the road to economic independence and social change often begins in the fields of one's own community. By turning a college hiatus into a multi-dimensional success, she proves that modern agriculture is a path to both dignity and prosperity.



National Pride: Kupwara Scholar Secures All-India Rank 2

In a resounding victory for academic excellence in North Kashmir, Yasmeena Ayoob of Bcherwara Kralgund, Handwara, has secured an extraordinary All-India Rank 2 in the prestigious NET-JRF Urdu examination. The daughter of Mohammad Ayoob Bhat, Yasmeena's journey to the pinnacle of national academia is a masterclass in consistency and grit; after graduating as the topper from Women's College Baramulla in 2020, she completed her Masters at the University of Kashmir with a stellar 74.5 percent and subsequently qualified for the JKSET in 2023. Currently a PhD scholar at the renowned Jamia Millia Islamia, New Delhi, she previously cleared the NET in June 2025, but her relentless pursuit of excellence led her to this monumental achievement—cracking the Junior Research Fellowship (JRF) with a near-perfect 99.9 percentile. Competing among twelve lakh candidates across the country, Yasmeena's triumph stands as a beacon of inspiration for the border district of Kupwara, proving that intellectual dedication transcends all geographical boundaries. Crediting her success to the unwavering support of her parents and a personal philosophy rooted in sacrifice and determination, she reminds aspiring scholars that true success is built on the pillars of patience and hard work. Her milestone not only brings immense pride to the region but also reinforces the power of education in shaping the leaders of tomorrow.



Yasmeena Ayoob
"SUCCESS IS ALL ABOUT HARK,
DETERMINATION, PATIENCE,
CONSISTENCY & SACRIFICE."

Architects of Change: Celebrating Handwara's Women Achievers

In a powerful tribute to female leadership and grassroots excellence, the 'One to One' Women Achievers Award 2026 illuminated the auditorium of Boys Higher Secondary School, Handwara, on February 17, 2026. Organized by the Jammu Kashmir National Youth Forum in collaboration with My Chotta School Handwara and Kashmir Flow Tour and Travels, the event served as a prestigious platform to honor educators, professionals, and community leaders who are actively reshaping the social fabric of North Kashmir. Chief Guest Rafiq Ahmad Mir, Deputy CEO Kupwara, emphasized that recognizing these achievements is vital for fostering equal opportunities and social support, enabling every woman to realize her full potential. The ceremony was graced by distinguished figures including philanthropist Dr. Aabidah War and Mrs. India 2018 Nusrat Parveen, who urged the next generation to strive for excellence across all fields. Among those celebrated for their notable contributions were Advocate Barkat Kour Ratthan, Mehjabeen Nabi, and Saima Sahafi, representing a diverse spectrum of professional triumph. As Chairman Irfan Kashmiri noted, this initiative is just the beginning of a sustained effort to strengthen the cause of empowerment, proving that when the women of Handwara are honored, the entire community rises in dignity and progress.



Echoes of the Soil: Riyaz Ul Hassan's Digital Crusade for Kashmiri

In the heart of Pulwama, educator Riyaz Ul Hassan is pioneering a linguistic revolution that bridges the gap between global connectivity and ancestral roots. By utilizing social media as a dynamic classroom, Hassan is teaching English through the lens of Kashmiri, effectively encouraging children and youth to rediscover the value of their mother tongue. His digital efforts are not merely about translation; they are a vital cultural intervention helping to revive spoken Kashmiri and grant the language a growing global reach in an increasingly digital world. Hassan's work addresses a critical challenge facing the "young ambassadors" of the Valley—the risk of linguistic isolation in a rapidly



modernizing society. By creating engaging, relatable content, he transforms individual learning into a community-wide mission of heritage preservation. This movement aligns with the broader spirit of resilience seen across North Kashmir, where local leaders are reclaiming their narratives through education and collective action. As these digital lessons ripple across platforms, they serve as a poignant reminder that true progress lies in embracing one's identity. Through the tireless grace of educators like Hassan, the timeless sounds of the Kashmiri language are finding a new, vibrant home in the arenas of the future.

Empowering the Future: Mission YUVA Fuels Entrepreneurship in Budgam

In a decisive move to bolster local livelihoods, the Deputy Commissioner (DC) of Budgam recently conducted a comprehensive review of the progress under Mission YUVA. The review highlighted a significant surge in youth self-employment across the district, with thousands of applications already verified and approved, signaling a robust movement toward economic independence. This initiative is a cornerstone of the broader commitment to transform the "young ambassadors" of the region into successful entrepreneurs and job creators.

To maintain this momentum, specific directions were issued to relevant departments to expedite bank sanctions and the disbursement of subsidies. By streamlining these financial hurdles, the administration aims to ensure that the transition from aspiration to action is seamless for the district's youth. This effort mirrors the "Grit and Resilience" seen in neighboring districts like Baramulla and North Kashmir, where collective action is reclaiming the narrative of progress. As Mission YUVA continues to unfold, it serves as a powerful testament to a Budgam that is dedicated to fostering a safer, united, and prosperous society through the timeless grace of community support and administrative diligence.



GLACIAL GRIT : Shafiqa's Six-Wicket Haul to a Two-Run Thriller

On February 12, 2026, the pristine white landscapes of Gurez transformed into a theater of grit and sporting excellence during the much-anticipated Girls Exhibition Match of the Gurez Snow Cricket Premier League (GSCPL). The clash between Habba Khatoon Cricket Club and Dard Shina Club was a landmark moment for female empowerment in the valley, showcasing talent that rivaled the sharpness of the winter air. After Dard Shina Club won the toss and posted a target of 50 runs

in 12 overs, the chase became a high-stakes drama. Habba Khatoon Cricket Club fought valiantly but were ultimately bowled out for 48 runs in 11.1 overs, handing Dard Shina Club a thrilling two-run victory with just five balls to spare. The defining performance came from Shafiqa, whose devastating six-wicket haul earned her the Player of the Match honors. Graced by Judge Munsif Gurez, Ms. Mehak Mehboob, the ceremony distributed medals and cash prizes, reinforcing

a commitment to girls' participation in sports. This exhibition was more than a match; it was a powerful statement that the youth of Gurez are ready to shatter glass ceilings, even on a pitch made of ice.



Volleys in the Valley: Tulail's Historic Sporting Debut

The scenic heights of Tulail Valley witnessed a historic milestone from February 12 to 14, 2026, as the inaugural Sheikhpoora Volleyball Competition ignited the Jurnial grounds with high-octane energy. Co-hosted by local authorities and the Indian Army, this landmark tournament brought together six dynamic village teams—the Niru Knights, Dangithal Tigers, Jurnial Hunters, Sheikhpoora United, Wani Wizards, and Khan Warriors—all battling for glory in the heart of Bandipore. The opening day's Pool A action saw the Jurnial Hunters emerge as the dominant force, securing decisive victories over both the Dangithal Tigers and the Niru Knights to claim their stake in the tournament. Beyond the fierce rivalries and professional-grade spikes, the event served as a vital platform for promoting fitness and unity among the region's youth, drawing enthusiastic crowds from across the frontier district. Local leaders have hailed the competition as a defining moment for rural sports development, proving that even in the quietest corners of North Kashmir, the spirit of competition and national pride can reach new, soaring heights.



BARAMULLA'S SPORTING RENAISSANCE: A VISION OF MODERN HORIZONS AND EMPOWERMENT

Nestled in the verdant folds of North Kashmir's Baramulla district, where the Jhelum River carves timeless paths through snow-draped peaks, a transformative wave is sweeping the sports landscape. The District Administration has inked a pivotal Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the National Hydroelectric Power Corporation (NHPC) under its Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiative, pledging ₹1 crore to significantly elevate local infrastructure. This funding is set to upgrade the Mini Stadium at Uri and install high-mast floodlights at the General Bipin Rawat Stadium, enabling day-night events and fostering year-round pursuits in cricket, football, and hockey. This initiative aligns seamlessly with broader governmental efforts, including the release of ₹137 crore for sports upgrades across Jammu & Kashmir for the 2025-26 period, and ₹195.05 crore under the Prime Minister's Development Package for multipur-

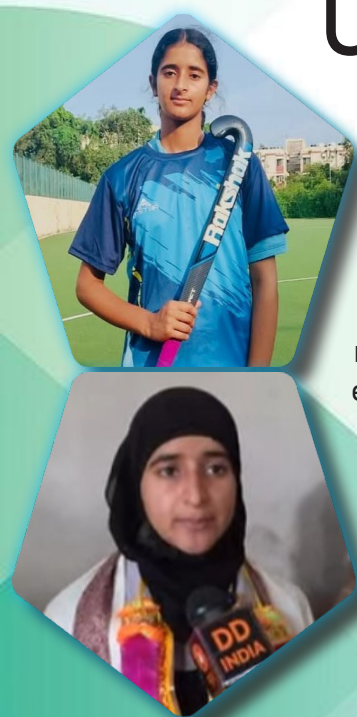


pose indoor halls and stadium renovations. In Baramulla, future plans envision a state-of-the-art stadium featuring tip-up seating under tensile roofing and a dedicated indoor badminton arena, promising to nurture talent even during the region's most challenging winters. Baramulla's revival is successfully transforming these historic valleys into vibrant arenas of triumph and hope.

On the Fast Break: Uznaain Ashraf and The New Era of Kashmiri Hockey

Uznaain Ashraf's standout performance at the Junior Women's National Hockey Championship has resonated far beyond the turf, serving as a powerful beacon of pride for Jammu & Kashmir. Her success is not merely an individual achievement but a reflection of the rapidly expanding horizons for youth and women in the Valley's sporting landscape. As she navigates the competitive stage of national hockey, Uznaain embodies the "Grit and Resilience" that has become a hallmark of North Kashmir's athletic identity.

This milestone comes at a time when the region is witnessing unprecedented investment in sports infrastructure, from the installation of high-mast floodlights at the General Bipin Rawat Stadium to the development of multipurpose indoor halls. Such facilities are bridging the gap for female athletes, providing them with the professional platforms needed to transition from local grounds to national glory. Uznaain's journey highlights a significant shift: sports are increasingly viewed as a viable path for empowerment and community engagement. By shattering stereotypes with every goal and assist, she is inspiring a new generation of "young ambassadors" to pick up the stick and pursue excellence. Her story is a testament to a Kashmir that is successfully transforming its historic valleys into vibrant arenas of triumph and hope.



The Sacred Crescent: A Tapestry of Faith and Tradition in Kashmir

As the holy month of Ramadan dawns upon the Valley, an atmosphere of profound devotion and reflection envelopes Kashmir, drawing worshippers to mosques and shrines in a collective search for spiritual solace. The faithful observe the rigorous dawn-to-dusk fast, a period dedicated to self-discipline and the teachings of Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) that strengthens the communal bond with the Divine. Amidst this sacred rhythm, unique local traditions endure; the rhythmic calls of sehri drummers still echo through neighborhoods, awakening residents for the pre-dawn meal as they have for centuries.



The culinary landscape shifts beautifully with the season, as local bakeries overflow with the scent of fresh lavasa, kulcha, and bakirkhani, typically enjoyed with the comforting warmth of traditional noon chai. Iftar remains a cherished ritual, breaking the fast with dates and basil-seed drinks before progressing to aromatic mutton curries and the creamy delight of phirni. Central to this observance is the spirit of Zakat, where selfless acts of charity towards the underprivileged transform individual piety into a community-wide mission of compassion. In every prayer and shared meal, Ramadan in Kashmir serves as a poignant reminder of a heritage where deep spiritual fervor meets the timeless grace of Kashmiri hospitality.

Echoes of the Past: The Sehri Drummers

Amidst this sacred rhythm, unique local traditions endure; the rhythmic calls of sehri drummers still echo through neighborhoods before dawn. This centuries-old practice continues to awaken residents for their pre-fast meal, resonating deeply in many areas across the Valley as a cherished link to the past.

A Culinary Journey Through the Valley

The culinary landscape of Kashmir shifts beautifully with the season, blending spiritual observance with local flavors:

Traditional Bakeries: Local bakeries overflow with the scent of fresh lavasa, kulcha, katlam, and bakirkhani.

The Morning Brew: These breads are typically enjoyed with the comforting warmth of traditional noon chai (salted tea) during sehri.

The Ritual of Iftar: Breaking the fast remains a cherished ritual, beginning with dates or basil-seed drinks.

Aromatic Feasts: Evening meals often progress to aromatic mutton curries, rice, and fruit chaat, concluding with the creamy delight of phirni.

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THE PULSE OF PATRIOTISM: TREHGAM'S VISION FOR A FEARLESS FUTURE

IN MEMORY OF THE PULWAMA BRAVEHEARTS

On the seventh anniversary of the tragic Pulwama Attack—a day forever etched in the national memory by the supreme sacrifice of forty brave souls the township of Trehgam rose in a powerful, collective display of patriotism and resolve. Organized by the local civil society, the “March for Unity” transformed the streets into a vibrant testament to the spirit of “Unity in Diversity” and an enduring commitment to a future entirely free from the shadow of terrorism. Approximately 270



enthusiastic students from local schools, joined by youth of all ages, walked hand in hand from the historic Jamiya Masjid to the bustling Trehgam market. These young ambassadors of a new era, with eyes reflecting a profound and unwavering love for their land, carried on their shoulders the weight of a monumental responsibility forged in a collective promise to eradicate fear. This march was not merely a commemorative walk; it was a vivid portrayal of the bright future of Kashmir, underscoring a frontier region that stands firmly for peace, progress, and national integration. As these young voices echoed through the district, they sent a clear message: the true spirit of Kashmir is defined by its resilience and pursuit of national harmony.



Answers Of Jan edition quiz are

- A. DR. A.P. J. ABDUL KALAM
- B. RATAN TATA
- C. INDIRA GANDHI
- D. SARDAR VALLABHBHAI PATEL

Winner

ASLAM SHAIKH
(RESIDENT OF LANGATE)

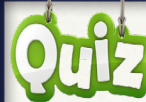
EMPLOYMENT UPDATES

1. CUSTOMER CARE EXECUTIVE JOBS IN AIRTEL
(CONTACT: +91-9906363515 ,HR.SGR@AITIPL.COM)

2. KV SRINAGAR JOBS 2026
(CONTACT: E-MAIL: PKVNOISGR@GMAIL.COM
WEBSITE: [HTTPS://NOISSRINAGAR.KVS.AC.IN](https://noisrinagar.kvs.ac.in))

3. VARIOUS JOBS IN FORCE MOTORS J&K 2026
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7006214686

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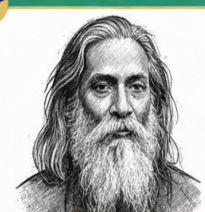
Test Your Knowledge of India's Treasures!

MONUMENTS



1. Identify this "Crown of Palaces"

PERSONALITIES



2. Poet, Patriot, Nobel Laureate?

CUISINE



3. A fragrant, layered delight?

LOCATIONS



4. "God's Own Country"